

writing skills you'll need to create stellar essays. You should also take advanced-level courses in other core subjects.

3. Log community service hours

Many scholarships require a certain number of service hours; and time serving the community can help you become a more experienced and compassionate person.

4. Go to summer camp

Many colleges and universities offer pre-college programs or specialty camps in areas such as music, art, theater, media, and computers. Not only do these programs allow campers to explore interests and improve skills, but they also allow department heads to identify rising stars (and potential scholarship winners).

5. Apply for as many as possible

More money is (nearly always) better. The more money you can bring in from outside sources, the less you or your parents will have to pay. Scholarships can reduce financial aid packages, but since this aid is often in the form of self-help or student loans,

it is wise to offset your needs with free money as much as possible.

6. Be organized

Kimberly indicated that the process is time-consuming, and that the students who win scholarships tend to be entrepreneurial (they consider finding scholarship money similar to running a business). They are well-organized, meet deadlines, quick to respond, and persistent.

7. Know your competition

Call scholarship providers and ask how many students apply and how many awards are given each year. This can help you prioritize and tailor your applications.

8. Compile and gather information

If the applications require documents such as transcripts or letters of recommendation, make sure to get those ahead of time. Going to your favorite teacher to ask for a letter of recommendation one day before your application is due is not a sign of a responsible student. Also start brainstorming for essay ideas early—you'll probably have to write several of them.